

Document 2. Command Word Grid

One-page reference: command words, mark allocation, and technique. This grid is calibrated to the SEAB 9570 mark scheme conventions. Use it to read questions correctly and budget time per part.

Section A. Master Command Word Table

Command word	Typical marks	What it asks for	Technique to score full marks
Identify / State	1–2	Pick out one or two pieces of information from the source.	Quote / paraphrase the data point with units. Do NOT explain.
Define	1–2	State the precise economic meaning of a term.	Use the textbook definition word-for-word.
Describe	2–3	State the main features or trend without explanation.	Trend (rising / falling / fluctuating) + magnitude + time period + turning points.
Compare	2–4	Identify similarities AND differences with reasons.	State similarity, state difference, support each with data.
Account for	3–6	Give reasons for an observed outcome, supported by data.	Each reason: claim → economic mechanism → data link.
Explain	3–6	Show how / why something occurs.	Definition → economic mechanism → diagram (if relevant) → outcome statement.
Analyse	6–10	Break a concept into parts; show cause-and-effect chain; usually a diagram.	Frameworks (DD/SS, AD/AS, externalities). Always: define → diagram → step-by-step explanation → link to question .
Discuss	8–15	Two-sided treatment: strengths and weaknesses.	Two-paragraph structure (<i>thesis</i> + <i>anti-thesis</i>) followed by a brief synthesis.
Assess / Evaluate / Comment / Discuss the extent / To what extent	8–25	Make a judgement supported by evidence.	Two-sided body → stance → weighted evaluation → context-aware conclusion. Use the C-E-F test: <i>Constraint</i> → <i>Effectiveness</i> → <i>Feasibility</i> .
Justify	4–8	Defend a single stance with evidence.	State stance → give two supporting reasons with data → pre-empt counter-argument.
Suggest / Recommend	4–10	Propose a policy with reasoning.	Identify the problem → pick the policy with the best fit → explain transmission → flag one limitation.

Section B. Mark Allocation Conventions

Paper 1 (CSQ). Each CSQ is 30 marks. Typical parts: 2, 3, 4, 6, 8, 10. **8-mark and above parts always require evaluation.**

Paper 2 (Essays). Each essay is 25 marks: **(a) 10 marks** (no evaluation required) + **(b) 15 marks** (evaluation expected). The conventional split for the 15-mark part is roughly 10 marks for analysis and 5 marks for evaluation.

Section C. Reading the Question: a 3-step protocol

Step 1: Underline the command word. Match it to the row above. Decide if evaluation is required.
Step 2: Box the topic. What concept, market or policy is being tested?
Step 3: Circle the context. What country, time period, or industry is named? This is non-negotiable: every conclusion must apply to this context.

Section D. Common Pitfalls

- **Ignoring the command word.** Students often write a full discussion when the question only says “Explain”. Mark scheme will cap your score.
- **Mis-reading “Account for” as “Explain”.** “Account for” requires data citation; “Explain” may not.
- **No evaluation in 8+ mark parts.** Evaluation is treated as a separate level descriptor and capped if omitted.
- **Defining beyond what is needed.** If the question says “State”, do not waste sentences explaining.
- **Not anchoring to context.** A correct generic answer about “a small open economy” loses marks if the question is set in Singapore.

NOTE: Time budget rule of thumb: 1 mark = 1.5 minutes (Paper 1) or 2 minutes (Paper 2). For a 10-mark part, target 15–20 minutes including a diagram.